

6.3 Recovery to the Bisector

BETWEEN ONE SHOT and the next, a tennis player has to stand somewhere. Where that somewhere should be is one of the few questions in the sport with a geometric answer, and the answer is not the middle of the court.

After striking the ball, a player recovers: they move back toward a waiting position to prepare for the reply. The instinctive choice is the centre mark, the small line in the middle of the baseline. It looks fair. It sits the same distance from both corners, and a player who has just been pulled wide feels the pull of it. But the centre mark is only the correct answer when the ball is also in the centre, and most of the time it is not.

The reply the player has to cover is not a single shot but a range of them. The opponent, standing where they are, can hit anywhere between two extremes: the straightest ball down the line, and the sharpest angle across the court. Those two extremes fan out from the ball and enclose every reply that is physically available. Coaches call the shape they enclose the *reply cone*. The player's job is not to guess which shot inside the cone is coming; it is to stand where no shot in the cone is far away.

That place is the *bisector*: the line that cuts the reply cone into two equal halves. Standing on it does not shorten every run, and it is worth being clear about that. It shortens the *longest* one. Move off the bisector in either direction and the reply on the far side moves further away, and it is the furthest reply, not the average one, that decides whether a ball is reached at all.

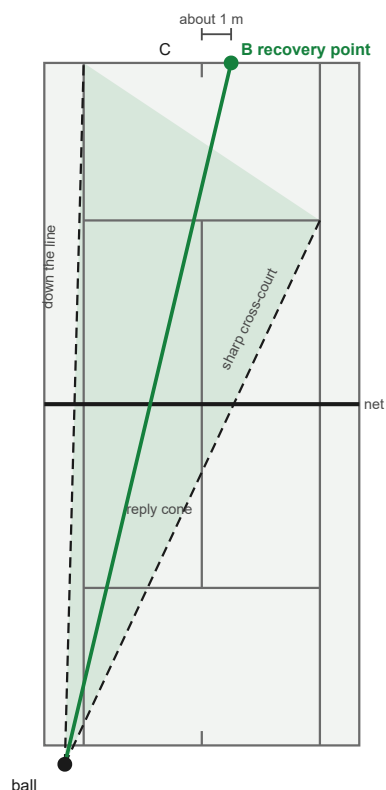


Figure 6.4 The reply cone and its bisector. The ball is wide on the left of the opponent's baseline. The two dashed lines mark the straightest and the sharpest replies available from there; everything the opponent can hit lies between them. The solid line divides that wedge into two equal angles and meets the player's baseline at B. The centre mark, C, sits about a metre to the left of it.

Figure 6.4 shows the consequence that surprises most players. The ball is wide on the player's left, and the recovery point sits to the *right* of the centre mark, away from the ball. The instinct is the opposite: to drift back toward the side the ball is on, because that is where the last shot was. But the danger is not where the ball is. The danger is the open court the opponent can now reach, and that court is on the other side.

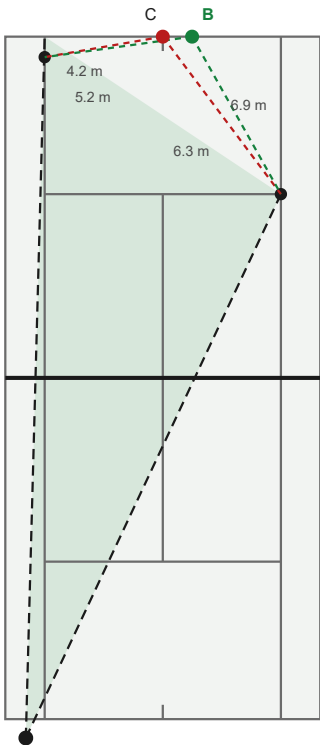


Figure 6.5 Covering from C against covering from B. The same ball and the same cone, with the two balls that have to be covered marked: one deep down the line, one short and sharp across court. From the centre mark the runs are 4.2 m and 6.9 m; from the bisector they are 5.2 m and 6.3 m. Moving to B makes the shorter run longer, which is the cost, and the longer run shorter, which is the point. The centre mark is equidistant from the *corners of the court*, but not from the *shots that are actually available*.

The trade in Figure 6.5 is the whole idea in miniature. A player at the centre mark covers one reply beautifully and the other barely at all; a player on the bisector covers both adequately. Only one of those survives an opponent who aims at the gap. And the word that does the work is *available*: the centre mark is a fact about the court. The bisector is a fact about the situation. A player standing at the centre mark is defending a court; a player standing on the bisector is defending against an opponent.

Because the bisector is drawn from the ball, it moves whenever the ball moves. There is no fixed spot to return to and no habit that survives more than one shot. A ball hit to the opponent's left produces one recovery point; the same opponent, two steps to their right, produces another. The player who has memorised a position will be correct occasionally and by accident. The player who reads the ball will be roughly correct every time, which in a rally is worth far more.

Table 6.2 Where the ball is, and where to recover

Where the ball is	Where to recover
Centred on the baseline	The centre mark: the cone is symmetrical
Wide on the player's left	A step or so right of the centre mark

Where the ball is	Where to recover
Wide on the player's right	A step or so left of the centre mark
Short and wide	Further across, and closer in, because a short ball opens a sharper angle

This is also why recovery is described as a movement rather than a place. Between the moment a player finishes their shot and the moment the opponent strikes theirs, the correct standing point is still being determined by a ball that is still travelling. Good recovery is not arriving at a spot. It is arriving at the spot the ball has just finished defining.